



Above With an almost diplike texture, creamy *kibbeh nayyeh* should be scooped up with Lebanese flatbread

Right The stunning new Mohammed al-Amin mosque is modeled on the Sultan Ahmed Mosque in Istanbul



The Best Places to Eat Kibbeh Nayyeh

Abdel Wahab moderate

A bastion of tradition in one of Beirut's most fashionable districts, Abdel Wahab is a sure bet for authentic *kibbeh nayyeh* in a charming setting. Occupying an attractive Ottoman house in a Monot side street, the dining area is an enclosed courtyard, which is suitably untainted by 21st-century trappings. The waiters are used to serving vast meze spreads, which they deliver with speed and efficiency.

From the olives and pickled vegetables to hummus and tabbouleh, the dishes begin arriving thick and fast. Abdel Wahab has a reputation for using only the best butchers, some of whom are from the famous meat markets of Sabra, so the *kibbeh nayyeh* here is one of the freshest in the city. Beautifully presented in pink swirls, it has a richness that will flood your palate with flavor, and a texture as smooth as paste. Those of a sterner constitution might enjoy *sauda nayyeh*, or raw lamb's liver and fat cubes, served with little mounds of pepper and ground spices for dipping. Meze is all about contrasts, so have a mix of hot and cold dishes, from barbecued chicken livers to stuffed vine leaves. When a long meze lunch in the mountains is just out of reach, Abdel Wahab is the next best thing.

El Inglizi Street, Monot, Achrefiyeh, Beirut; open noon–midnight daily; +961 1 200 550/1

Also in Beirut

You'll find a refreshingly contemporary take on Lebanese cuisine in **Babel** (+961 70 425 777; *moderate*), a breathtaking new restaurant on the Dbayeh Highway on the outskirts of town. The cavernous dining room is high and wide, built of huge blocks of sandstone. It's like dining at a palace in ancient Baalbek, but the *kibbeh nayyeh* has a thoroughly modern twist – served in individual, bite-size portions, rolled and dotted with black sesame seeds like sushi.

Also in Lebanon

Twenty minutes' drive from Beirut is the mountain retreat of Brummana, where **Kasr Fakhreddine** (www.fakhreddine.com; *expensive*) has sweeping valley views of the Chouf Mountains and great *kibbeh nayyeh*. For a distinctly northern Lebanese version of the dish, **Le Mortier** (+961 3870 507; *inexpensive*) in the town of Ehden near Tripoli has a beautiful setting and *kibbeh* in all of its wondrous forms, both raw and cooked.

Around the World

There are more people of Lebanese extraction living outside Lebanon than within. Brazil has one of the largest migrant communities, and São Paulo's **Almanara** (www.almanara.com.br; *inexpensive*) has been preparing and serving authentic meze, including *kibbeh nayyeh*, since the 1950s.